

The Last Summer

by Sydney Wentz

The summer Margot turned sixteen, the lake dried up for the first time in anyone's memory. It didn't happen all at once — it was gradual, the way all losses are, the water pulling back a little more each morning until one day her father stood at the edge of what used to be the dock and looked out at a field of cracked mud and said nothing at all.

She had spent every summer of her life at that lake. She knew its moods the way she knew her own — the way it went silver before a storm, the way the far shore disappeared in August haze, the particular cold of it in June, before the sun had had time to reach the deep parts.

Her grandmother said the lake had a name before it was called Lake Harrow. A name in a language nobody in the family spoke anymore, a name that meant something like: the place where water remembers itself. Margot had written it down once in a notebook she no longer had.

She walked out onto the lakebed the morning after her father's silence. The mud had hardened into scales, into the pattern you see on the backs of old maps where the cartographer ran out of knowledge and just drew lines. Her sneakers left prints that filled slowly with nothing.

At the center of where the lake had been, she found a rowboat lying on its side. She didn't know whose it was. She had never seen it on the water. It was the green of something that had been underwater for a long time, the green of forgetting.

She sat inside it and looked up at the sky, which was the same sky it had always been, indifferent and enormous and blue. A hawk circled once and didn't come back. She thought about all the things the lake had been holding down there in its cold dark — everything that had ever been dropped, everything that had ever sunk, everything that had ever gone in and not come back out.

It was all still there. Just visible now.